

HIGH SCHOOLS / BASKETBALL TOURNAMENTS

Warrensville Heights wins its first district title

By EDDIE DWYER
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

He took a deep breath, took one last glance at the scoreboard and smiled.

To say that Warrensville Heights' junior center/forward Darnell Sanders was a satisfied young man last night would be an understatement.

"It's the first time it has ever happened to our school," Sanders said after he helped the Tigers to a 71-60 victory over Copley in a boys Division II district championship basketball game in Solon.

"Now, we just have to keep playing strong."

With Sanders getting stronger as the game went on, Warrensville Heights wrapped up its first district basketball championship. The Tigers, members of the Lake Erie League's Erie Division, will take a 13-11 record into Wednesday's 6:15 p.m. regional semifinal in the University of Akron's JAR Arena. Warrensville Heights' opponent will be two-time defending state champion Villa Angela-St. Joseph (17-6).

"I'm extremely proud of these guys," Tigers coach John Simmons said. "They went through the hard times, the pain of losing.

But they seem to have persevered. They have learned from it, and now we are playing as a team."

Warrensville Heights, which features several underclassmen, came out running and pressing and held a 17-6 lead after junior guard Tyrone Savage hit a jumper in the lane with 4:40 remaining in the first quarter.

But with the Tigers in early foul trouble, Copley was able to chip away, cutting the deficit to 19-17 on a layup by junior center Jason Harris.

Behind a 3-pointer by senior guard Ozell Dobbins, a 15-footer by junior guard Thomas Greene

and a baseline jumper by Sanders, Warrensville Heights pushed its lead to 26-17 midway through the second quarter.

Copley, which closed its season 10-14, got its half-court offense clicking and went on a 16-6 run. The Indians tied the score, 32-32, on baskets by junior forward Ted Schneider and Harris, and took a 33-32 lead on a free throw by senior forward Andy Ward with 1:16 left in the first half.

"We just had to keep running on them," Sanders said. "They couldn't keep up with us as long as we kept the pressure on and maintained our intensity on defense."

Going to Sanders early and often in the third quarter, the Tigers increased a 34-33 halftime lead to 48-40 on a power move inside by Sanders with 2:33 left in the quarter. Sanders, whose 25 points tied him for game honors with Harris, scored eight points in the third quarter, 16 in the second half.

"He's just a monster inside," said Simmons of the 6-5, 215-pound Sanders.

After Copley cut the deficit to 50-46 on a running, one-handed slam-dunk by Harris with 7:01 remaining, Warrensville Heights went back inside and increased its lead to 56-48 on a spinning one-hander by Sanders and two

free throws by Savage.

Another spin move inside by Sanders made it 61-52 with 4:11 left, and the Tigers, controlling the boards down the stretch, sealed their first regional appearance at the foul line.

"We knew they would come out after us," Copley coach Duane Daily said. "But I thought we did a good job of regaining our composure and getting back in it."

"I knew we would scratch, that we wouldn't fold. But turnovers and offensive rebounding, those were the keys for us. Sanders is a tremendous post player and basically, we play seven kids. So they were passing the ball and we were running all the time."

Hoban locks away win

Put-back does it at the buzzer

By TIM ROGERS
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

ALLIANCE — The girls from Archbishop Hoban pushed the envelope on the adage that good things happen to those who wait.

The Lady Knights waited until the game's final second to defeat Brookfield,

47-35, to win the Division III regional basketball championship yesterday in the Timken Physical Education Building on the campus of Mount Union College.

Senior Angie Lockhart scored on a put-back as time ran out to send the Lady Knights to the final four for the first time since the school won the Division II state championship in 1988. Hoban (19-7) will play Cincinnati Wyoming (23-2) on Friday at 4 p.m. in the state semifinals. Wyoming defeated Utica, 43-34, yesterday.

"It put me in shock," Lockhart said of her winning basket, which followed a miss by teammate Jacki Windon. "I will never forget this for as long as I live."

It marked the second straight year that Brookfield lost to a Catholic school from Akron in the regional finals. The Lady Warriors (19-7) lost to St. Vincent-St. Mary last year, and the Irish went on to win the state championship. Maybe that bodes well for Hoban.

"It seems like it's our destiny," Hoban coach Loralee Daily said. "Everything has fallen into place."

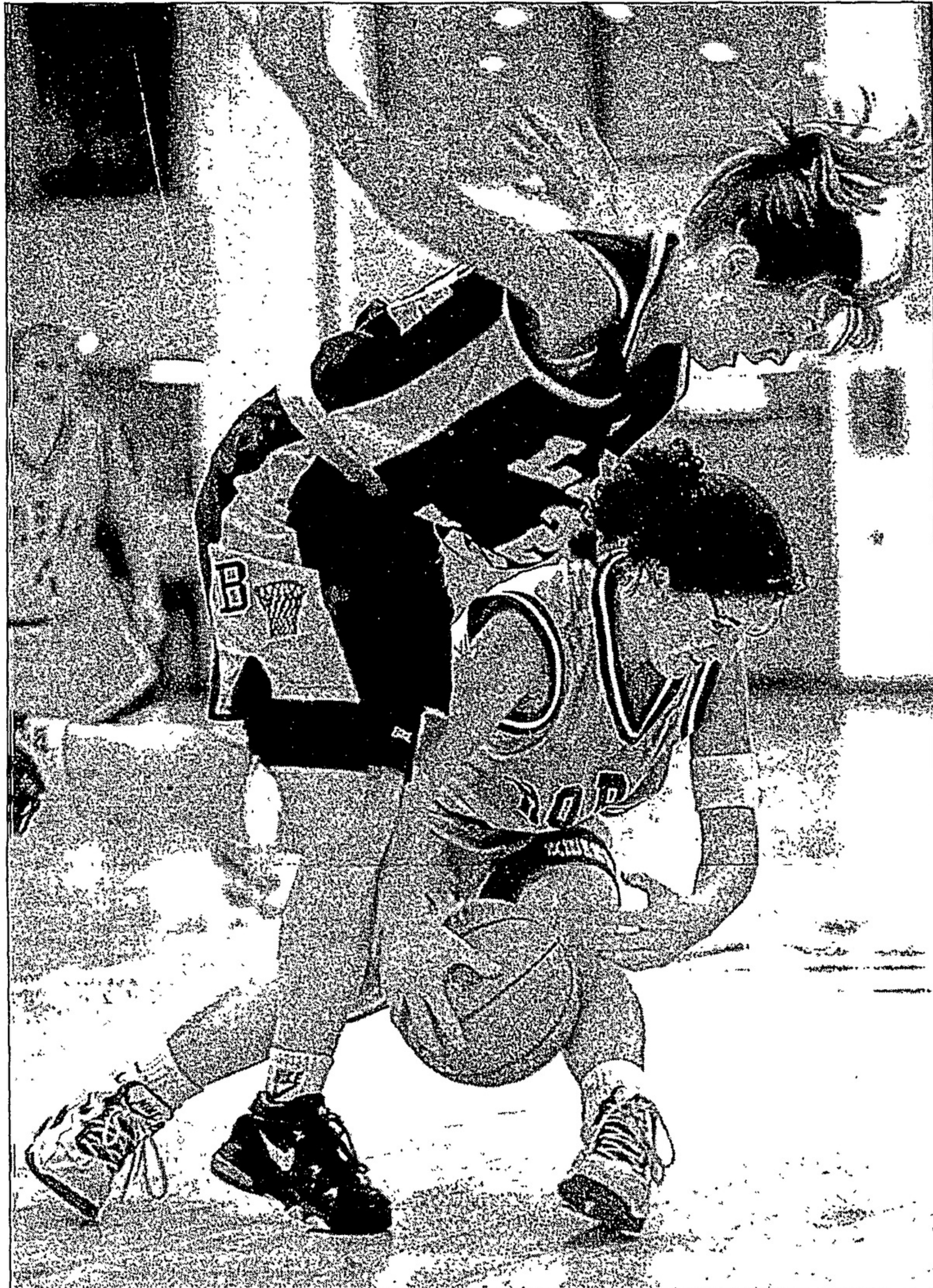
Nothing fell into place more nicely than Lockhart's basket, which capped a fourth-quarter rally in which Hoban outscored Brookfield, 12-5, while holding the Lady Warriors scoreless for the final 2:12 after trailing, 30-25, entering the final eight minutes.

"Usually, the ball goes in when Jacki shoots it, but I thought I'd crash the boards anyway, because that's what coach has always told us," said Lockhart, a 5-11 post player who led Hoban to a 35-28 rebounding edge with a game-high 11, including eight on the offensive end. "When I got the ball I said: 'Just put the ball back up.'"

And when did Lockhart realize that her shot had beaten the buzzer?

"When everyone started hugging me and was going, 'Aaaaggggh,' " she said.

Overtime was a distinct possibility after Brookfield sophomore Christy Reiser split two free throws to tie the game, 35-35, with 13 seconds remaining. Windon, the Knights' leading scorer during the regular season, attempted an off-balance jump shot from near the foul line. The ball hit the rim and fell to the right side, where Lockhart had



PHIL LONG / ASSOCIATED PRESS PHOTOGRAPHIC

Brookfield's Karen Prater tries to avoid fouling Hoban's Gina Seminaroti during the Lady Knights' 37-35 Division III regional championship victory yesterday.

positioned herself.

It was Windon who had given the Knights their first lead since early in the third quarter. Trailing, 34-33, with 1:08 to go, the 5-2 junior glanced at the bench as she brought the ball up court, dribbling with her right hand and patting herself on the chest with her left, signaling Daily that she wanted to call her own number.

"In situations like that we want the ball in Jacki's hands," said Daily.

Windon dribbled around the perimeter before penetrating and scoring from just inside the foul line to put the Knights on top, 35-34.

Neither team had a banner day shooting. Hoban made 16 of 60 field goal attempts (26.6 percent) and Brookfield was 16-of-45 (35.5 percent). Senior Megan Beal led Hoban with 14 points, getting more than half her team's points (11) in leading the Knights to a 21-17 halftime lead. Windon had

11 and Lockhart finished with six. Senior Karen Prater led Brookfield with 16 points. Hoban had a 19-7 edge in offensive rebounds.

"We had a definite height advantage," said Daily, who is taking a team to the final four for the first time. "We didn't go inside as much as I would have liked, but we were able to get the offensive rebounds when we needed them."

And none was bigger than the one hauled down — and put back up — by Lockhart.

Novak said he wanted to get the ball to Kevin Coffey, who scored 25 points, for the final shot in regulation. "We were trying to isolate him but they kept pushing us out," he said.

"We had a mishap," said Coffey. "Some players were supposed to cut, but they didn't."

After falling behind, 61-59, on Brown's layup in the overtime, the Vikings turned it on. Jerome

Olmsted Falls tops Rocky River at end

By DENNIS MANOLOFF
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

The Olmsted Falls boys basketball team redefined patience last night.

Waiting until virtually the last instant to take their first lead of the game, the Bulldogs defeated Rocky River, 36-34, in a Division II district final at Admiral King.

Forward Jerome Moore banked in a 2-footer with less than two seconds left to send Olmsted Falls to its fourth regional appearance in seven seasons.

"I wish we could have done this easier, but I'll take it, anyway," Bulldogs coach Pat Donahue said. "I'm so proud of our kids for hanging in there."

Donahue's heavily favored Bulldogs (21-2) overcame an outstanding effort from their Southwestern Conference rival, Rocky River (14-10) masterfully executed a slowdown strategy.

Moore's basket, his only points of the game, came off a short lob pass from guard Tim Matus. By the time the ball bounced on the floor, the buzzer sounded.

"That play was not even close to how we diagrammed it," Donahue said with a tired grin. "But I'm not going to complain. Everybody did their jobs."

With 1:40 left and the score tied, 34-34, Rocky River controlled the ball. Forty seconds later, during a drive inside, the Pirates misconnected on a pass and the Bulldogs gained possession.

They called timeout with 30 seconds left, and Matus instructed that a last-shot play go to

the Bulldogs' ace, 6-8 center Tim Schaefer.

"We wanted to cross-screen for Tim, but River did a good job of denying him the ball," Donahue said.

Guard John Storey, smartly eschewing the Schaefer option, dribbled on the wing with less than 10 seconds to play. He flipped the ball to Matus, who drove inside.

"When I drive, I always look backside block, because I usually can find one of our big guys for a layup," Matus said. "Jerome was right there. He did a great job to get open and made a terrific shot. I don't know how he banked it in."

Moore had stepped into the lane when his defender stepped up to help on Matus.

"I have to thank Tom for passing me the ball," Moore said. "This is a great feeling."

"The best feeling I've ever had in basketball," Matus said.

"That was anything but the case in Bulldogs' camp for 31 minutes, 58 seconds, as Rocky River controlled the tempo and scoreboard. Spreading the floor and handling the ball as if it were crystal, the Pirates had leads of 11-2 after one quarter, 23-19 at the half and 31-25 after three. The advantage grew to 33-25 early in the fourth on two free throws by Chad Standing.

Rocky River coach Jim Rucki implemented the slowdown strategy in response to previous losses to Olmsted Falls of 87-64 and 71-52.

"I figured it was the best chance we had of beating them," Rucki said, "and we almost pulled it off. We probably made a few too many turnovers, especially down the stretch."

Chanel ends Chagrin Falls' season

By DON FRIEDMAN
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Point guard Izzy Santiago means so much to the Chanel boys basketball team, whether he is in uniform or sitting on the bench with his crutches.

His teammates all wore his No. 10 on a patch on their jerseys as they went about the business of defeating Chagrin Falls, 64-47, in a Division III district championship game in the Maple Heights gym last night.

Santiago dislocated his left knee in a district semifinal victory over Lutheran West on Thursday. He will not play, but he will be on the bench to provide moral support for the Firebirds as he did last night.

Chanel's next stop is the Canton Fieldhouse, where it puts its 22-1 record on the line against Manchester in a regional semifinal game Thursday at 8 p.m.

The Firebirds were the odds-on

favorites to handle Chagrin last night, but it wasn't a cakewalk in the first 10 minutes. The Tigers got off to a surprising start and led, 12-11, with 5:40 left in the first half.

Chanel was not only playing without its point guard, but 6-7 scoring machine Marques Evans found himself on the bench with two fouls in the first six minutes.

Darcel Bouyer got the Firebirds going with nine points in the second quarter, and Alfredo Jackson scored eight. Chanel had taken control by halftime with a 26-18 lead.

Evans returned to the game at the start of the third quarter and came through with the team's first six points in less than two minutes. He scored nine in the third quarter, and Damon Fann scored six in the period. Chanel was up, 47-34, after three.

Bouyer finished with 18, Evans had 16 and Jackson and Fann each scored 11.

The Firebirds are wearing red warm-up T-shirts with the words "Unfinished Business" on the

back.

Santiago explained Chanel was knocked out of last year's tournament by Aurora in the district finals. They intend to go all the way this year and have been wearing those shirts since the preseason.

"I can't play, but I can always remember them wearing my number," Santiago said. "With the point guard missing, that takes a lot out of a team, but in the second half they started playing together tonight. I have confidence in them."

Evans thought Chanel was too aggressive at the start.

"We were too hyped up at the start, and we kind of fell flat," he said. "I got into foul trouble real quick. I thought our guys did a good job considering we were playing without Izzy. The team tried to do what Izzy would have done."

"Vernell Jackson, [Dan] Hall and [Damon] Fann all helped out."

Jackson started in Santiago's place.

"I was the point guard at John

Adams last year," Jackson said. "Adams closed and I came here. This is the first time I've been on a championship-caliber team. I'm making adjustments and doing the best I can. I can do better."

Chanel coach Greg Kraleay was pleased with the quick adjustment his Firebirds have made.

"We had one day to prepare for this game," he said. "Vernell will find there is quite a difference playing point guard on this team. He had early butterflies, but we got through the jitters."

"The guys did a nice job. We have 10 players who can play. Bouyer, Fann and Alfredo Jackson stepped it up. Chagrin had more height than we did, but we were them down with our quickness and defense. We take pride in our defense."

At the start of the second half, the Firebirds pressed Chagrin so tightly, the Tigers might have had trouble breathing.

"We made the shots we had to make at the beginning, and that gave us a lot of confidence," Chagrin coach Jim Scitucco said.